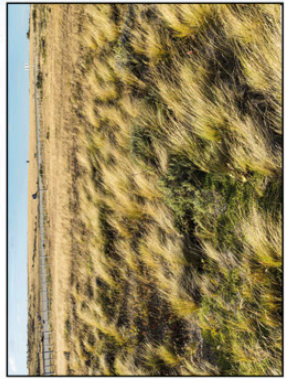


The Pampas

The grassy plains of the pampas lie in the southeastern corner of South America. The climate is generally dry with hot summers and cool winters. Lightning can cause fires in the dry grass, and farmers also set fire to the grass to encourage new shoots to grow, so some birds nest under the ground where they are safer from fires and people. Large cattle ranches on the pampas have damaged the natural environment. Only birds that can adapt to human disturbance, such as ovenbirds, have survived. Others have died out or decreased in number. Huge flocks of rheas are no longer common.



Rufous hornero
(*Furnarius rufus*)
Length: 9 in (23 cm)

Rufous hornero

The mud nest of the rufous hornero looks like an old-fashioned baker's oven, so these birds are sometimes called ovenbirds. (The word *hornero* means "baker" in Spanish.) It takes the bird months to build one nest, and yet it starts a new one each year. The rufous hornero has long legs and strides across open ground lifting its feet high in the air. It uses its strong, sharp bill to dig up worms and insect larvae.

The nest is made of thousands of lumps of mud, reinforced with straw and baked hard in the hot sun.

Southern caracara

These chicken-sized birds of prey are related to falcons. Caracaras build their own nests, unlike true falcons that use abandoned nests. They eat a varied diet from small mammals, birds, fish, and frogs to insects and dead meat—they often join vultures to feed on a carcass. Caracaras are slow and lazy birds, but they have long legs and can move quickly if in danger.

Greater rhea
(*Rhea americana*)
Length: 4 ft 6 in (1 m 40 cm)
Height: 5 ft (1 m 50 cm)

Greater rhea

The rhea is very similar to the African ostrich, except that it has three toes on each foot instead of two. It cannot fly, but it can sprint faster than a horse, reaching speeds of 31 mph (50 kph). In the breeding season, males fight for territory and for females. Several females lay their eggs in one male's nest and he looks after the eggs and chicks.

Rheas have three strong toes with claws on each foot for defense and for running fast.

Long legs for running swiftly if necessary.

Southern caracara
(*Caracara plancus*)
Length: 2 ft 1 in (64 cm)

Burrowing owl

Unlike most owls, burrowing owls are often active during the day. They usually live in other animals' abandoned mud burrows and spend a lot of time perched at the entrance. If disturbed, they bob up and down and make a chattering noise. Burrowing owls can run quickly over the grasslands on their long legs to catch their food, which is usually insects and small reptiles.

This owl nests in burrows made by viscachas and other animals, but it can also dig its own.

Burrowing owl
(*Athene cunicularia*)
Length: 10 in (26 cm)